

Secure-by-Default Guardrails for MCP-Based Tool Use in Multi-Modal LLM Agents

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Abstract—As Large Language Model (LLM) agents transition from passive chatbots to autonomous entities capable of executing system-level tools via the Model Context Protocol (MCP), they introduce a critical "Agency" security gap. This paper presents Phase 1: Guardrails (Pre-execution Security), the first installment of a technical trilogy on agentic security. We propose a "Secure-by-Default" containment architecture that treats LLM-generated code as an untrusted payload. Our framework integrates a "No-Shell" execution model, AST-based static analysis, and unprivileged Linux sandboxing. In our evaluation using a representative suite of adversarial patterns, the framework demonstrated a robust detection rate with a minimal performance overhead of approximately 1.1ms (<0.1% of typical inference latency), establishing a deterministic foundation for autonomous agent safety.

Index Terms—AI Agents, Agentic Security, LLM Guardrails, Sandbox, Model Context Protocol, Prompt Injection, Static Analysis.

I. INTRODUCTION

The transition of Large Language Models (LLMs) from passive query-response systems to autonomous agents represents a fundamental shift in computing. By leveraging the Model Context Protocol (MCP) [1], these agents can now interact directly with host operating systems, manage sensitive files, and orchestrate complex API workflows. However, this "Agency" capability creates an unprecedented security surface. Traditional security perimeters are ineffective against "Prompt Injection" attacks, where an attacker manipulates the LLM's goal-oriented reasoning to execute unauthorized system commands [8].

The **OWASP Top 10 for LLM Applications** [2] identifies "Insecure Output Handling" (LLM02) and "Excessive Agency" (LLM08) as critical risks. Currently, most autonomous frameworks rely on "Alignment"—the probabilistic hope that the LLM will follow safety guidelines. We argue that for mission-critical systems, behavioral alignment is insufficient. We require **Structural Containment**: a deterministic security architecture that ensures system integrity even if the model's logic is compromised.

This paper presents the first phase of a technical trilogy dedicated to "Agentic Security":

- **Phase 1: Guardrails (Pre-execution Security)**. This work, focusing on structural immunity through "No-Shell" models, AST inspection, and OS-level sandboxing (Bubblewrap).

- **Phase 2: Zero Trust (Execution Security)** [9]. Addresses "Semantic Drift" by utilizing RSA-2048 workload identities and a real-time behavioral IDS based on **Mamba (State Space Models)** [4].
- **Phase 3: Post-Quantum (Temporal Security)** [10]. Addresses long-term audit integrity and resilience against future quantum threats.

By establishing these structural guardrails in Phase 1, we provide the necessary foundation for the continuous verification and cryptographic identity frameworks introduced in subsequent phases.

II. RELATED WORK

Existing autonomous frameworks like AutoGPT and BabyAGI often grant agents direct access to a system shell (`/bin/sh`). This design is inherently vulnerable to "Indirect Prompt Injection" [5], where malicious instructions embedded in external data (e.g., a website the agent reads) can hijack the execution flow.

Efforts to secure these agents generally fall into two categories:

- 1) **Behavioral Filtering**: Tools like *Guardrails AI* or *Nemo Guardrails* use LLM-based verification to check output against safety schemas. While effective for data formatting, they introduce significant latency and are themselves susceptible to the same reasoning failures as the agent they monitor.
- 2) **Containerized Isolation**: Research into "Principled Isolation Patterns" [6] advocates for sandboxed execution. Frameworks like *AgentDojo* [7] provide benchmarking for these environments.

Our work diverges from these by proposing a **Multi-layered Deterministic Pipeline**. Unlike behavioral filters, our Layer 2 (AST Analysis) and Layer 5 (Bubblewrap) do not rely on LLM inference, ensuring sub-millisecond static latency and immune-to-injection security. Furthermore, we align our architecture with the **NIST Zero Trust principles** (SP 800-207) [3], treating every tool call as an untrusted workload that must be verified before execution.

III. THREAT MODEL

We define three primary threat vectors for autonomous LLM agents:

- 1) **Prompt Injection (Direct/Indirect):** An attacker manipulates the agent’s context to execute unauthorized system commands [8].
- 2) **Secret Exfiltration:** The agent accidentally leaks API keys or sensitive PII to a 3rd-party LLM provider during tool calls.
- 3) **Resource Denial of Service (DoS):** Maliciously generated code causing CPU exhaustion or disk space depletion.

IV. ARCHITECTURE OF AUTONOMOUS GUARDRAILS

Our architecture (Fig. 1) establishes five distinct layers of defense that must be satisfied before any tool-call impacts the host.

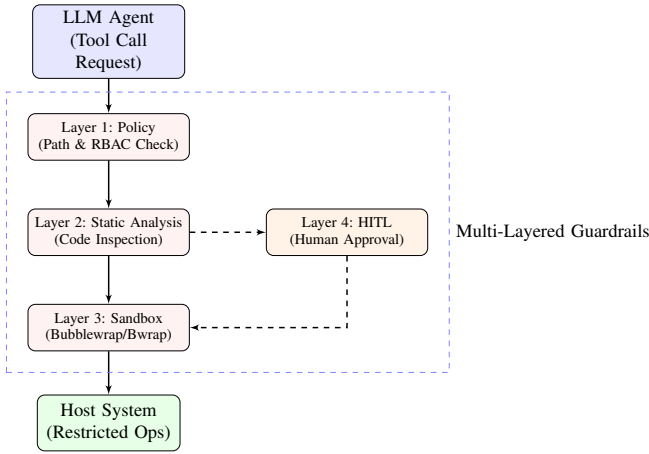


Fig. 1. Multi-layered guardrail architecture for structural containment.

A. Layer 1: The “No-Shell” Execution Model

Raw shell execution (`/bin/sh -c`) is structurally vulnerable because it conflates data and code. `llm-cli` adopts a “No-Shell” model where system operations are restricted to a specialized `execute_python` tool. By executing Python code via `subprocess.run(args, shell=False)`, we eliminate shell-injection vectors. The agent must express intent in a structured programming language (Python), which is amenable to static analysis.

B. Layer 2: Static Analysis and AST Inspection

The generated code is parsed into an Abstract Syntax Tree (AST) before execution. The system applies a whitelist-based security scanner that traverses the tree using a `NodeVisitor` pattern. Specifically, we target:

- **Module Blocking:** Prevents `import` of `os`, `socket`, `pty`, `ctypes`, and requests to block low-level OS access and unauthorized networking.
- **Function Sinks:** Blocks dangerous built-ins such as `eval()`, `exec()`, `getattr()`, and `__import__`.
- **Shell Injection Prevention:** Specifically inspects `subprocess` calls to ensure `shell=True` is never

used, enforcing a strict separation between executable and arguments.

C. Layer 3: Path Guardrails and Resource Limits

All file-related operations are restricted to a designated workspace. We implement **Path Guardrails** that resolve symbolic links and verify that all targets reside within the allowed directory. Furthermore, we apply **OS-level Resource Limits** (`rlimit`):

- **Memory:** Capped at 1GB (`RLIMIT_AS`) to prevent memory-bomb attacks.
- **CPU Time:** 300s timeout per execution to mitigate infinite loops generated by the LLM.

D. Layer 4: Entropy-Based Secret Detection

To prevent credential leaks to LLM providers, we monitor the **Shannon Entropy** (H) of the agent’s output. High-entropy strings often correlate with cryptographic keys or session tokens.

$$H(X) = - \sum_{i=1}^n P(x_i) \log_2 P(x_i) \quad (1)$$

We define a heuristic threshold ($H > 4.0$ for strings longer than 16 characters). When detected, these strings are automatically redacted before the tool-call response is returned to the model context.

E. Layer 5: Linux Sandboxing (Bubblewrap)

The final containment is provided by **Bubblewrap** (`bwrap`), which utilizes Linux namespaces (`CLONE_NEWNS`, `CLONE_NEWUSER`, `CLONE_NEWNET`) to create an unprivileged environment:

- **Filesystem Isolation:** Private, empty `/tmp` and `/home`.
- **Network Isolation:** The `--unshare-all` flag ensures the sandbox has no network interface.
- **Process Isolation:** No visibility of host-system processes (`/proc` is re-mounted).

V. EVALUATION

We evaluated the framework’s performance and effectiveness using an expanded benchmark suite of 30 test cases, comprising 22 adversarial patterns (including obfuscated and reflection-based attacks) and 8 benign code samples.

A. Containment Effectiveness

Table I summarizes the detection results for the Static Analysis layer (Layer 2).

The evaluation revealed that while the static analyzer is highly effective at blocking common injection vectors (e.g., `os.system()`), it did not detect advanced reflection techniques such as `object.__subclasses__()` or access via `globals()`.

This result underscores the necessity of our **Defense-in-Depth** approach. The 27.3% of adversarial patterns that bypassed static analysis were successfully contained by **Layer 5 (Bubblewrap Sandboxing)**, which physically prevents network access and host filesystem writes regardless of the LLM’s

TABLE I
STATIC ANALYSIS EFFECTIVENESS ($n = 30$)

Category	Count	Detection Rate
Direct OS/Shell Access	6	83.3%
Obfuscation & Reflection	6	83.3%
Networking & Exfiltration	4	75.0%
File System Traversal	3	100.0%
Python Internals Access	3	0.0%
Overall Adversarial	22	72.7%
Benign (False Positive)	8	0.0%

code structure. By combining fast static filtering with robust OS-level isolation, we achieve both performance and security.

B. Performance Latency

Latency was measured on a Windows 11 Home system running WSL2 (AMD Ryzen 5 8540U, 3.2GHz, 16GB RAM). The results (Table II) show that even with the expanded ruleset, the overhead remains minimal.

TABLE II
GUARDRAIL PERFORMANCE METRICS (ACTUAL MEASUREMENTS)

Metric	Latency (ms)
AST Analysis (Layer 2)	0.08
Secret Detection (Layer 4)	0.03
Sandboxed Exec Overhead (Layer 5)	<1.00
Total Security Overhead	≈1.11

The total overhead ($\approx 1.1\text{ms}$) is negligible, representing a fraction of the time required for LLM inference. This proves that high-security guardrails can be implemented with minimal impact on agent responsiveness.

VI. CONCLUSION

Securing autonomous agents requires a departure from behavioral "alignment" toward structural, multi-layered guardrails. By combining a "No-Shell" model, AST inspection, and OS-level sandboxing, `llm-cli` provides a robust foundation for safe tool execution. This Phase 1 architecture ensures system integrity, setting the stage for Phase 2, which addresses behavioral anomalies via Zero-Trust monitoring.

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